Stand: The Rosa Parks Story

by Stephanie Spencer



Stand: The Rosa Parks Story by Stephanie Spencer

ISBN: 978-1-61387-043-3

Copyright 2013 by SpeechGeek.

Free performance of this play for high school and college level competitive forensics is permitted. All other rights reserved.

This PDF version of this selection, e-published in 2013, is identical to the printed published version of this same publication dated 2013. This statement along with the entire printed PDF of this publication must be presented at any National Forensic League District or National event for the script to comply with NFL rules per the request of the Executive Director.

This and other selections of quality performance literature for competitive oral interpretation are published by SpeechGeek.

For more information and performance rights, contact **SpeechGeek.**

SpeechGeek
248 Arlington Park Dr.
Hot Springs, AR 71901

Phone: 1-888-742-2028
Email: thegeek@speechgeek.com
Web: www.speechgeek.com
Facebook: www.facebook.com/speechgeek

SCENE ONE

(*An old Rosa Parks is waiting at a bus stop*.)

ROSA. Mmm-hmm. As usual, I'm just waiting to take the Cleveland Avenue bus home. Yep, I'm still riding them. Seems a little silly for me, of all people, not to. Can you imagine me, Rosa Parks, taking a taxicab? That don't even sound right.

When I was a girl there were thirty-six seats on a Montgomery bus. First ten were only for whites, even if there were no white passengers on the bus. There was no law about the last ten seats, so you know what that means. Mmmhmm, they were for us black folk. That's right. And if those filled up then we had to stand. And when we wanted to get on the bus they had to pay in the front go around and climb into the back. Shoot! Some days I think I wasn't even resisting segregation that day in 1955. I was just tired and wanted to sit down!

(*chuckles to herself*) It seems I took a stand by sitting.

SCENE TWO

ROSA. I know what they say about me in the books, nowadays. But I'll be the first to tell you, I was a regular person. I was just as good as anybody else. That's why all this started.

One of my earliest memories was a remarkable time right after World War 1. I was five or six years old and a soldier from the north patted me on the head and said I was a cute little girl. Later that evening, my family just couldn't quit talking about how the Yankee soldier had treated me like I was just another little girl and not a little *black* girl.

I think it was right around that time that I was old enough to realize that we were not actually free. The Klu Klux Klan was riding through the black community, burning churches, beating up people, and even killing people. At one point, the violence was so bad that we'd go to bed with our clothes on

so we'd be ready to run if Klansmen broke into our house.

Sometimes I'm asked how I lived with that kind of fear. The only way I knew how: I got me an attitude.

Any little thing I could do, I did. It wouldn't be anything of great significance, but it was my small way of expressing hostility. I remember that sometimes I would call white men by their first names or their whole names and not say "Miss" or "Mister."

Never really lost that attitude. It drove my grandma mad. She once remarked that I was much too headstrong. If I weren't careful, she said, I'd be lynched before I reached twenty years old. She said I was "so high-strung that I was going to get myself strung high."

I don't mind telling you that it hurt when she said that. I felt I was very much in my right to defend myself. It was later that I came to understand that she was scolding me because she was afraid for me. It wasn't because she thought they were right but because she thought they was stronger than her—stronger than justice.

When I was older, I joined the National Association for the Advancement of Colored People all because of folks like Recy Taylor. A black woman on her way home from church, Recy was kidnapped and raped by six white men. A grand jury refused to indict the men even though the driver of the car confessed and named his accomplices.

You see, that was the 1940's when people took a lot without fighting back. They bowed their heads and said their "misses" and "misters."

But look at me. Do I look like someone who can take a whole lot? No. I mean, here it was half a century after the first segregation law and there were 50,000 African Americans in Montgomery. More of us rode the buses than whites did. It was humiliating riding

segregated buses twice a day and five days a week just to go downtown and work for white people.

The Montgomery N.A.A.C.P. was beginning to think about having a boycott of the city buses. That'd really hurt the bus company. I remember them asking a few people if they would be willing to stay off the buses to make to make things better for us and them saying that they had to go too far to work. Folks thought a petition would be a good start. I didn't feel anything could be accomplished with a piece of paper in my hand asking white folks for any favors.

I knew that the only way we could fight was by filing suit against the city of Montgomery over bus segregation. But they had to have the right plaintiff and a strong case. The best plaintiff would be a woman because a woman would get more sympathy than a man. And the woman would have to be above reproach, have a good reputation, and have done nothing wrong but refuse to give up her seat. So yes, we were planning on setting up a scene.

But that is not why I refused to give up my bus seat to a white man on Thursday, December 1st, 1955. I did not intend to get arrested. I did not intend on starting the Civil Rights Movement. Tell you the truth, if I had been paying attention I wouldn't have gotten on that bus in the first place.

See, what happened was when I got off from work that evening, I went to Quart Square, as usual, to take the Cleveland Avenue bus home. A bus came and, without even checking the number, I got on.

SCENE THREE

(*The scene is a flashback of a YOUNG ROSA confronting a BUS DRIVER.)*

YOUNG ROSA. Here's my dime.

BUS DRIVER. Get off the bus and go to the back door and get on.

YOUNG ROSA. (*sighs*) Sir, I'm already on the bus and I'm very tired. I don't really see the need of getting off and then getting back on. Can I just go on through?

BUS DRIVER. Them's the rules, get off and get back on or just get off.

YOUNG ROSA. Sir, there are no seats back there and I don't know how I'm going to squeeze in.

BUS DRIVER. Look, if you can't get through the back door and sit back with your kind, then get off my bus.

YOUNG ROSA. (*thinks about it*) No.

BUS DRIVER. Excuse me?

YOUNG ROSA. I said NO. (*YOUNG ROSA sits down in the front seat.*)

BUS DRIVER. Get up or I'll call the police.

YOUNG ROSA. You may do that sir, but I'm not moving.

BUS DRIVER. Are you crazy?

YOUNG ROSA. I do not accept being pushed even at the cost of my life. I was raised to be proud and I have no need for some white person to disapprove of me sitting down in an empty seat. I'm tired, tired of *all* of this. So, no!

BUS DRIVER. You're going to jail!

YOUNG ROSA. Then you're driving me there in this here seat!

SCENE FOUR

(*The older ROSA returns to the audience.*)

ROSA. Like I said, that attitude never did go away. So they arrested me, of course. Shortly thereafter the Montgomery bus boycott began.

Some people think it only took a few months for things to change, but that ain't true. It took generations. I think of it now, it took us the whole of our history in this country for things to change. If you wanna know the truth, I think it's sad and terrible that so many people know my name but not nobody know the name of the hundreds of thousands of black folk who died before me. I try to remember what it takes for one person to be regular. It takes a lot of folks fighting hard to get you there. And here I am, just a regular person that a lot of folks think changed the world. Imagine what anybody else can do.

It's nice to see how far we come. (*looks up*) Ah, my bus is here. But we've still got a long way to go.